Imitations

By Nancy Larson

DERELICT: *(Angry)* Somebody's been here all right. Don't try to tell me any different now. That would only make me mad 'cause then I'd know for sure that you was one of them pack of liars out there. . . Don't even talk to me about liars, I hate them so much! *(He uses a stick to draw a semi-circle around the playing area in front of the audience. He is near tears)* Don't nobody cross that there line! Okay? We got that straight? Good . . . Hey, hey, listen now. I got no personal grip with you. All you gotta do is to just to understand that this is my home, that's all. *(beat)* You know, I'm not always like this. I mean, I'm usually a nice guy. Ask anybody. It's just that . . . It's just that . . . Well, if you must know *(takes a deep breath)* I once kinda liked this girl, but she got in an accident last night. She passed away with her panties twisted down around her ankles *(he shivers)* Gives me the creeps just to think about it. I thought you oughta know that right off the bat so's you won't get all bent outta shape later on.

INTRODUCTION

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DERELICT: She had these gigantic blue eyes that made you feel that you were swimming. I mean drowning. Oh, yeah, also, she wore pearls in her ears. Hey, that reminds me . . . I know it's in here somewhere. *(he digs in his pocket, turning it inside out to carefully retrieve a "diamond" – holds it up for inspection)* I was saving this for a special occasion. *(he sighs)* Know what

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it is? Yes sirree Bob. A genuine diamond. Found it right exactly here in the dirt. Right here. I was going to give it to her. *(he sits down to ponder the situation, staring at the "diamond." Angry)* So, now what am I supposed to do? Huh? *(he tosses the diamond into his mouth and swallows it)* HEY! *(he jumps to his feet and pulls up his sleeve to check his nonexistent watch)* Oh boy oh boy oh boy oh boy. *(he takes out a greasy sack from his bag)* It's lunch time. *(he takes half-eaten food out of the sack and sets them to one side. Next he takes out a number of French fries and ritualistically arranges them in a neat row)* She loved French fries. *(he gobbles up his food, speaking with his mouth full)* If a body knows where to hunt, then there's no good reason in the world why he can't eat like a king. Sometimes about this time I take a little schnoozaroo. And when I do *(he pulls a long scarf from his bag)* I tie this around me like so. *(he lifts his various undergarments to tie it around his bare middle)* Know why? It's so the devil can't get into me through my belly-button when I'm asleep. It works pretty good too, most of the time. *(he pulls the scarf off of himself)* I don't have to do that now, 'cause I can't sleep. My brain only wants to think about her.

The first time I met her was when I'm taking my regular siesta and I hear this click, click *(makes the sound with his tongue)* It was her, crouched up in front of me. She was taking my picture with a camera. I was kinda mad. What a thing to wake up to: click, click, click. My brain musta shown through my eyes, 'cause she stopped. *(He giggles)* Her skirt had crept up way above her knees. *(listens to something unheard)* Who me? *(pointing to himself, as if talking to an unseen person)* What I wanted to talk about? . . . What? Okay. Okay. It's okay now. I remember. So! It turns out that she was a college student and had to take a lot of silly

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pictures and ask a lot of dumb questions to pass the grade. Boy, let me tell you, have things changed. I once went to college, you know. Auto mechanics college. I might not have been the smartest kid in the class, but I sure as heck wasn't the dumbest either! I could have been a mechanic. [But] next thing you know, here I am. *(defensively)* And here I'm gonna stay. 'Cause I like it here. And so did she. She took so many pictures of this place, and of me, and she asked me every sort of question that you cold imagine. Like, know what she asked me? She asked me where do I go to the bathroom. Now, isn't that a stupid question? You don't just go around asking people stuff like that. No! So I was really mad and I clammed right up. I ended up forgiving her. . . 'specially since she brought me this five-course never-been-touched-before dinner from Jack – 'N – the – Box. Well, before you knew it, she was getting nicer and nicer. Jeeze, she practically lived here, 'cept at night, you know. *(Proudly)* See this coat? *(smells the torn coat he's wearing as one would smell a flower)* She gave it to me, tied up in red ribbons and all. I got so choked up. Know what she said to me? "Can't let my best boyfriend freeze to death." She said that. Honest to God. My best boyfriend. So you can see what it wasn't long before she had me doing my imitations. Bet you didn't know I did imitations. That's cause I never used to do them for people, till she came along. Like, Marlon Brando *(doing an impression)* STELLA! Or how 'bout this? *(he does Ed Sullivan and Donald Duck or whatever – be creative)*

Hey, don't make any mistakes, 'cause she wasn't all perfect and sweet. I wouldn't want you to thin that, oh no. She was darn good at saying some pretty depressing things at time. Like telling me that sooner or later

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they wouldn't let me live here any more and that I'd have to start making plans for my future and what not. *(he puts his hands to his ears, elbows out)* I'm not listening to you No I'm not. *(to drown out her voice)* Do di do di do di dum di dum! *(suddenly another voice breaks in)* I'm gonna turn you over my knee and spank you good, making messy all over my house. *(drops his hands)* Something like that could really ruin a guy's day, believe you me. Just between you and me, I think that she wanted to kiss me on the lips 'cause she moved in real close to look into my eyes. *(closes his eyes and pulls her to him)* Ooh, Ooh, Ooh, now . . . *(his eyes fly open)* WHAT? Oh, God, no! WHAT! *(he throws himself to the ground and puts his ear to the earth, listening)* Oh, no. Uh uh. They ain't coming to get me yet. No siree! *(puts his ear to the ground to listen again. He jumps up, defiantly brushing himself off)*

So she comes back day after day, taking her dumb pictures and asking her crumby questions. *(softening)* But then she goes and asks me where my mother is. So I told her that my parents died in the Holocaust, 'cause I once heard somebody say that and it worked really good. She seemed pretty surprised and asked me what country that happened in. so I told her Minnesota! Boy did she look at me strange. Up till then I was sure that a holocaust was when there was a hurricane and lots of people die, then the locusts come and eat at their dead bodies. *(gets lost in the imagery for a moment)* Then she puts her hand on my shoulder real sweet-like and again she asks me about my mother! *(Angry)* Well, hell's bells! That girl just don't know when to quit! I was so mad. I was finished with her and her lousy questions! Sinking her teeth into me. Sucking me dry. And what'd I get? A big fat nothing zero, that's what.

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I was doing fine before I met up with her. Just fine! And you know what? She's crying. Jesus Christ, she's crying. She is really crying. I can't believe it. Then she starts apologizing all over the place. Something really weird happened when I saw those tears. So I tell her it's okay. Then she takes my arm *(fixates on his arm in a creepy way)* and it feels exactly like she and me are connected, like we're sharing the same blood. Boy, did that ever feel good.

(Suddenly hysterical) Oh, God . . . Oh, God . . Oh, God . . . Where's my poison apple. I'm not afraid to die. *(he runs to his apple hiding place, frantic)* Where is it, where is it, where is it? Whew! *(he finds his apple, shoves it into his mouth, devouring it hungrily. Mouth full)* If there's a God, then let this apple kill me! *(he crumples to the ground in pain. He squirms and jerks in the throes of death's agony. Suddenly he stiffens. Dead . . . a few seconds of silence. He sits up, he looks around, puzzled. He slaps himself a few times in the face)* It didn't work . . . it didn't work. *(depressed and bitter)* You know what she thought? She thought I drink wine all the time. But I don't. She could be such a big liar sometimes. Boy, could I ever use a drink now.

You shoulda seen how pretty she looked coming up the path with that picnic basket. I was so happy to see her I thought I was gonna pee in my pants. Until. Until. I see this jerk following behind. Guess what? Big surprise. The jerk's her boyfriend. That's what she called him. Her boyfriend! Can you believe it? Bringing him her, calling him that? It stinks rotten, if you ask me. I made me want to throw up. I guess I made the jerk kinda uncomfortable, seeing as I wouldn't answer his jerky questions. *(Giggles)* Every time he opened his fat trap I would

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make a face like this *(he sneers)* I couldn't help it. The guy had a talent for causing me to make faces. Know what I hear her say to her boyfriend? "Don't worry, honey. Sometimes he gets a little moody. He'll be all right." And where does she get off talking to some jerk about me, huh? Well maybe I won't be all right! Just maybe I won't be! Did she ever think about that? *(Screams at them)* Maggots! Maggots! Maggots! Maggots! *(pauses to collect himself)* Then, all of a sudden it hits me. *(he hits his forehead as he says the words in the same alternate voice from before)* What's the matter with your brain? That's how come the jerk won her away from you! I made some plans. I would go back to college ad become an auto mechanic and I would give her that diamond and we would get married. I know, don't ask me why, that she's gonna come the next day. I know pretty soon I'm gonna see her. And I do. She give me this wide wave like she's waving to an aeroplane. So I stick out my arms and run as fast as I can to her (he runs like an aeroplane, making the appropriate noise) By the time I reach her I can't even talk. All I can do is grin like an idiot. And as we're standing there catching our breaths, she looks at me all soft and feathery and says, "I missed that silly face of yours." Well, that's all it took, boy. I start saying things like *(he mimics himself)* I missed you too, really a whole lot. All I did was think about you and make up songs about you and talk to God about you. So I tell her. About my plans. About me marrying her and all. Oh, oh. Something's weird. All of a sudden she's not smiling any more *(quotations around her voice)* "I came here because I like you and you're one of my good friends, but . . ." *(Confused)* What did she say? . . . What came next? . . . What did I do? . . . *(he groans, covering his face with his hands and rocking back and forth)* Oooooh . . . Oooooh . . . Ooooh . . .*(he holds his head as*

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if it's about to explode) If there is a God . . . If there is a God, then please, please, pretty please . . . *(drops his hands)* Don't do this to me. I'm warning you. Don't do this to me now. *(he loses touch with reality)* The damage is done and done and lies and lies and over and over and over and going up and going down. *(taunting alternate voice)* Ain't never had a girl. Have too. No. You ain't never had a girl. I have too! I have too! *(puts his hands over his ears)* Lies! Filthy lies! *(covers his eyes to avoid a horrible sight)*

(long beat as he composes himself) You know, I'm not always like this. I mean, I'm usually a nice guy. Ask anybody. It's just that . . . It's just that . . . Well, if you must know *(takes a deep breath)* I once kinda liked this girl, but she got in an accident last night. She passed away with her panties twisted down around her ankles *(he shivers)* Gives me the creeps just to think about it.

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